> The wretched women are rendered quite insensible by means of certain drugs, in order that they may feel no pain. For this purpose opium is used, or a soporific herb named bang…. …sometimes they are half-drugged: and before they lose their resolution, are hurried to the pyre with warnings, prayers and promises of eternal fame. On arriving there they cast themselves into the flames. If they hesitate, the wretched creatures are driven on to the pyre; and if they try to leap off again, are held down with poles and hooks.

Akbar was always very sensitive to the predicament of the women around him, and regularly brought up issues concerning the happiness and safety of the women in his empire. Having discussed the number of wives permitted by Islam, Akbar now raised the issue of monogamy in the ibadat khana. ‘Under the principle of attachment to one another, which is the foundation of the arrangement of the universe,’ he said, ‘it would be eminently preferable that one should not marry more than one wife in a lifetime.’ In these discussions Akbar was beginning to demonstrate an awareness, rare for the times, of the vulnerability of women and the need to protect them in a society which inevitably favoured men.

The Jesuits were also startled to discover that one of Akbar’s closest confidantes, Shaikh Mubarak, ‘an exceedingly pious old man who was devoted to the study of religious commentaries and books of religious medication’, had but little faith in orthodox Islam. They found that the shaikh and his two sons ‘openly declared that the Koran contained many impious, wicked and highly inconsistent passages, and hence they were convinced that it had not been sent by God’. The priests, added Monserrate, ‘were astonished at this old man’s wisdom, authority and friendliness to Christianity’. They found others to be just as friendly. Abu’l Fazl even agreed to help out the Jesuits during the ibadat khana discussions by listening to their arguments beforehand so that he could then defend their position before the Muslim theologians more ‘fully and elaborately’ than they could. Indeed, Monserrate noted that Abu’l Fazl ‘seemed to be inspired by a divine earnestness, so clearly did he demonstrate how we believe that God has a Son’ and that the Jesuits themselves were astonished at his eloquence. One may easily surmise that Abu’l Fazl’s great efforts on behalf of the Jesuits were primarily to embarrass and humiliate the ulema, due to his ancient enmity, rather than because of any cherished spiritual beliefs about Christianity.